Calix

MODULE 1

CHAPTER 4

# Change Management

*Here's news that will not surprise you: AI has the power to change your company in profound ways. Here's more news that won't surprise you: When anything threatens to change your company in profound ways, you need to put in place a program of change management to help your employees, your leadership, and you through that change successfully.*

In the prior chapter we talked about the table stakes of change management—education and enablement. Now we dig in more deeply on what's required to lead your team through the transition to robust AI adoption and accelerated business growth.

### What You'll Learn

- Why change management is vital to successfully adopting AI
- A simple five-step process for building an effective change management program

## Preparing People To Work Confidently With AI

The flip side to the fact that AI has the potential to improve every role in your company is that AI has the potential to change every role in your company, and, as we know, change is not something people uniformly embrace. What's key, therefore, as you introduce AI into your company, is effective change management.

Change management isn't about controlling your people, it's about creating confidence in them. When done correctly, it helps every employee understand why change is happening, what it means for them, and how they can actively participate in it.

### 1 Assess and Build People Readiness

One mistake organizations often make when building a change management program is focusing too much on the goal or destination rather than the starting point. In other words: where are your people now? Effective change management begins by understanding your current state and meeting people where they are.

Another best practice is for leaders driving the initiative to model vulnerability and honesty. Admitting you don't have all the answers invites curiosity instead of fear and helps build genuine trust. It's important to remember that transformation is social before it is digital. Culture shifts happen when leaders communicate openly and create space for experimentation and play.

A practical way to understand your starting point is through employee surveys and focus groups. These can help uncover attitudes toward AI, as well as areas of uncertainty or concern, before change efforts begin. You can also leverage tools like the self-assessment introduced in Chapter 3 to give individuals a structured way to reflect on their current familiarity, comfort, and curiosity with AI in the workplace.

**Remember:** The goal isn't to eliminate discomfort, it's to acknowledge it and give it purpose through the context of the changes being undertaken.

### 2 Build Coalitions, Not Committees

Successful change spreads through relationships, not mandates. Identify a cross-functional AI Champion network with early adopters from across your company such as customer service, network operations, field technicians, sales, finance, or other departments that reflect your company's structure.

→ Give these champions early access to AI tools and learning resources.

→ Encourage them to share success: "What got easier this week because of AI?"

→ Empower them to raise obstacles quickly so issues are solved in real time.

To take this further, see Chapter 5: "Activating Your AI Leadership Team," where you'll learn how to formalize and scale this coalition into a sustained leadership capability.

**Key Insight:** Coalitions create cultural pull. People will follow peers who model what's possible.

## 3 Manage Resistance With Empathy and Evidence

Resistance isn't opposition; it's information. When employees hesitate, it's usually the result of one of three things:

- **Fear of loss:** "Will AI replace what I do best?"
- **Lack of clarity:** "How does this fit into my day-to-day work?"
- **Lack of confidence:** "Do I have the skills to use this responsibly?"

Address each of these issues with empathy and evidence:

✓ Reinforce that AI assists people, it doesn't replace them.

✓ Share real examples of productivity or service improvements.

✓ Offer hands-on, role-based training so confidence grows alongside capability (e.g., by leveraging Calix Education modules).

> **Key Insight:** Treat resistance as feedback helping you refine and improve your change management program and, as always, celebrate the gift of feedback.

## 4 Leverage Existing Learning Modules

An easy example of valuable training material from a trusted external source is the Calix Education & Success Portal. Below are examples of materials you can use to align learning tracks with each stage of AI adoption within your company. The goal is to help teams move from awareness to confident application one step at a time.

| Phase | Learning Module | Example Module |
|---|---|---|
| Awareness | "What AI is and why it matters" | Leading AI-Empowered Teams 🔗 Available Now |
| Activation | "Using AI in daily workflows" | Calix Cloud AI Capabilities Coming Soon |
| Adoption | "Driving results through data" | Applied AI for Customer Experience Coming Soon |
| Expansion | "Coaching with AI insights" | AI-Powered Performance Coaching Coming Soon |

One effective tactic to increase the uptake of this kind of training is to bake it into the normal workings of your company. For example, integrate each learning phase into regular team meetings, manager check-ins, or quarterly development plans so learning becomes part of the rhythm of the company, not a one-time event. When you do this, training progress can serve as a leading indicator of adoption readiness.

## 5 Communicate With Clarity and Cadence

People's fear of change is one thing, and we've discussed that above, but that fear can be made even more pronounced if there is confusion that goes along with it. A good communication plan around the adoption of AI will provide clarity, consistency, and a cadence that will reduce the fear of change across your employee base.

### Clarity

Always explain the why behind each change. Tie updates back to business intent and subscriber value.

### Consistency

Use unified language across leadership messages, internal posts, and meetings.

### Cadence

Communicate early, often, and again after milestones are achieved.

Create a two-way dialogue with your employees through Q&A sessions, office hours, or community forums. Again, welcome the gift of feedback.

## Chapter Takeaway

Effective change management is the bridge between AI strategy and AI success. By assessing readiness, building coalitions, managing resistance with empathy, leveraging existing learning resources, and communicating with clarity, you can guide your team through the transition to confident AI adoption.